asymptomatic spread for a long time: The *New England Journal of Medicine* published two papers on the possibility of asymptomatic spread, one of which was the German doctor's who studied the first few cases in Germany and wrote a letter to the editor on 30 January specifying, 'The fact that asymptomatic persons are potential sources of 2019-NCoV infection may warrant a reassessment of transmission dynamics of the current outbreak.'[12] In early February, the WHO noted in a report that patients might transmit the virus before showing symptoms. It also added that patients with symptoms were the main cause of the spread of the epidemic.[13]

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On 27 January, in a meeting at the PMO, the Cabinet secretary was informed that India had screened almost 30,000 passengers from 137 flights and that 12 samples had been sent out for further testing to the NIV. India had started distributing health cards on all flights with direct or indirect connectivity to China. Screening began on all international ports with traffic from China and of all visitors travelling across the Nepal border. Health staff were assigned to checkposts and all immigration officers and border security force officers manning these checkposts were sensitized.[14]

On 31 January, foreseeing the increased domestic requirement for PPE kits and N95 masks, the Indian Directorate General of Foreign Trade banned export of all categories of the former.[15]

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3 FEBRUARY 2020

INDIA | 4 ACTIVE CASES | 0 DEATHS

WORLD | 20,061 ACTIVE CASES | 433 DEATHS

Principal Secretary to the PM, Dr Mishra assembled a high-level group comprising senior officials in the PMO, NSA Doval, Chief of Defence Staff General Bipin Rawat and secretaries of several ministries.[16] The message from the prime minister was to immediately constitute a select group of ministers who would take responsibility and provide ground feedback from their respective constituencies regarding several logistical aspects as the